The Sabbath

Purpose: *To demonstrate from scripture that the Sabbath is a memorial of both salvation & creation.*

Centred on: *Jesus came to our world as the creator to re-create humanity in God's image. By his life and death he finished the work of salvation and rested in the tomb on the Sabbath.*

(day of grace, An intimate place in time, eternity enfolded in time)

Genesis 1:1-5, 2:1-3.. It is a chiasmic structure (day 1&4, 2&5, 3&6, 7) which shows a forming and filling action. He creates a space then fills a space – (Light/Sun, Water/fish, Land/animals/humans, himself), (it was Sanctified- set apart as Holy, Rest day, Worship day Lev 23:3)

Creation / Salvation

The next two texts refer not just to Creation but also Salvation

Ex 20:8-11…Celebration of creation (its important to God, he said "remember", to know & to keep it)

Deut 5:12-15.. These verses show the creation/salvation relationship (its all God's power and strength not ours) Celebration of their deliverance their salvation.

Mark 2:27,28…made for Mankind, (it was made after for us, not us after it- to keep it.)

Gen 1:1.. The creation story in parallel with..john 1:1

John 1:1.. Jesus is the active agent in the OT, also in the NT..in parallel with creation is salvation

This is interesting, the Bible uses creation terminology to describe salvation. For Example…

Creation / Salvation

The next three texts refer not just to Creation but to recreation which is Salvation

Psalm 51:10-12..David a moral sinner praying for salvation (create, restore). David uses creation language to seek salvation.

2 Cor 5:17… If any man be in Christ, he is a new creation. Salvation uses creative power.

Eph 2:8-10…Workmanship, Created

So what about the work

WORK

John 17:4… Q. Whats the work? A. The work of Salvation.

Q. Where does this idea of work come from. A. Genesis

John 19:30… Jesus has accomplished all this Salvation work for you, all you have to do is receive it. (Luke 23:54-24:3..when was the sabbath)

Isaiah 56:1-7.. Sabbath / Covenant

Exodus 31:13; Eze 20:12…sign of the creators ID

Acts 13:13-15… Gentile Christians who are also Sabbath keeping Christians

Acts 13:42-44.. Not just the Jews but the Gentiles also were keeping the Sabbath.

Will it be kept in the last days by God's people…

Rev 12:17; 14:7…Satan is angry at humans that follow God's law; We are called to Worship the creator of all things…a reflection of the Genesis account & 4th commandment.

Isaiah 66:22-23..Everyone in Heaven will be keeping the Sabbath. (Matt 24:20)

Isn't it beautiful that God is depicted as a God of grace in the bible. He has offered us a day to remember the creation/redemption gift.

So What day is the Sabbath?

Luke 23:54-24:3…Saturday (over 150 languages today call Saturday the Sabbath: German = Samstag, Spanish = Sabado, French = Samedi, Italian = Sabbato)

And When do we keep it, When does the biblical day start/finish…

Lev 23:32…same description of a day as Genesis 1.

How do we keep the Sabbath?

Neh 13:15-19; Isaiah 58:13-14, Ex 20:8-11…

How important is Sabbath-keeping? (Keeping in mind that it's part of the law)

1 John 3:4…Sin is lawlessness, "The wages of sin is death"(Romans 6:23)

James 2:10…Keep All the Law or none.

Hebrews 5:9…salvation to all who obey Him.

Our only safety is to diligently study the Bible (2 Tim 2:15). We must have positive scripture support for every Christian practice we follow.

Shouldn't we keep Sunday in honour of Christ's resurrection?

Romans 6:3-6…No, no more than you would keep Friday in honour of his crucifixion. Christ gave the ordinance of baptism in honour of his death, burial and resurrection.

What is stopping us or getting in the way of obeying God's word and worshipping him?

Jesus says “seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you” (Matt 6:33) and “Strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it” (Matt 7:14)

Difficult texts:

Revelation 1: 10…

It is true that latter in Christian history the term “Lords day” came to refer to Sunday. There is however, no evidence that the lords day referred to Sunday in the time of the writing of the New Testament. There are a couple of examples in early Christian history where the term Lords Day occurs. The Didache and writings of Justin Martyr.

An instructional manual entitled *Didache*, perhaps dating to the early second century, urges in its chapter 14 the following….

*“On the Lord’s (**Day**) of the Lord come together, break bread and hold Eucharist, after confessing your transgressions that your offering may be pure; but let none who has a quarrel with his fellow join in your meeting until they be reconciled, that your sacrifice be not defiled. For this is that which was spoken by the Lord, “In every place and time offer me a pure sacrifice, for I am a great king,” saith the Lord, “and my name is wonderful among the heathen.”*

Source: The Didache xiv. 1–3; in Apostolic Fathers, translated by Kirsopp Lake, Vol. 1 (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1959), p. 331. Reprinted by permission of the publishers and The Loeb Classical Library.

This text has been interpreted as referring to a weekly Sunday celebration, to an annual Easter, or *to the seventh-day Sabbath*. The problem however, lies in the fact that in the original Greek language, the word “DAY” is not documented! This was supplied at a later date by English translators. It reads, literally: “According to the Lord’s [?] of the Lord, coming together break bread and hold the Eucharist.” The context and nature of the statement, however, makes a totally different suggestion seem more viable: that instruction (or “command” or “doctrine”) is the noun to be supplied. This would give the reading, “according to the Lord’s instruction.”

Therefore, in order to cite this document as proof for the Lord’s Day, the thing to be proved must be assumed, and thus this quotation becomes of no value as proof. It must be interpreted in the light of other information. In later times, certainly, the adjective kuraikē, “Lord’s,” came to be used alone as a name for Lord’s Day, but this document is not proof of that use.

In Justin Martyr’s First Apology dated to approx A.D 155, there is reference to the Lords day being Sunday (see appendix). This document provides no evidence of the issue at hand as it is heavily influenced by the emerging culture of that time.

Consider this; words often change their meaning from one generation to another. For example if we go back only as far as the 1960’s, we find the extensive use of the word “Gay” as meaning “happy” yet today the meaning is applied to that of being homosexual. Interestingly, words often change their meaning the most in an emerging community. So at the time of Emperor Constantine’s “conversion,” when Christianity became legalised there was an unparalleled influx into this new

religion. Unfortunately, however, this rapid growth led to the people converting the church rather than the church converting the people. ***See appendix.**

So what does Jesus say regarding the Sabbath?

Mark 2: 28… If Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath, the Sabbath must be the Lords Day!

Isaiah 58: 13… here again we find Jesus stating the Sabbath to be "his holy day." Clearly this Old Testament writing is referring to the seventh day.

Exodus 20: 10… here we find conclusive evidence that the scriptures speak of the "seventh day" as being the Sabbath.

1 Corinthians 16: 1-3… This text is often referred to as evidence of Sunday sacredness, however it should be noted that according to the scripture we are encouraged to lay something aside. Paul is simply giving financial advice to not be left short changed at the time of the offerings.

Historians seem to indicate that during the early Christian church and the early Jews, never took offerings on Sabbath. This was probably due to the fact that most offerings were that of a "labour intensive nature" i.e. gains, livestock, clothing etc. these would be contrary to their principles of Sabbath adherence.

Roman 14: 5-6… This chapter is simply about opinions! If you read through the entire chapter, you will find no mention of the Sabbath. The issue being discussed here is simply that of diet choice and of fasting days. Paul is suggesting that one person esteems one day better for fasting and others esteem them alike. Paul is saying that we need to be persuaded in our own minds. The context here is not judging a person as to whether they are spiritual or not based on their own personal convictions. These are just people's preferences of what they feel they need to do. This has nothing to do with commands that God has given.

Acts 20: 7… Note: the dark park of the first day of the week is actually Saturday night. When God created the world, he stated that "the evening and morning" were the components of any given day (Genesis 1: 5). So rather than proving anything about Sunday worship, it seems more logical as a proof for Sabbath worship.

It seems more logical that Paul is spending his last Sabbath with his church, they continue meeting together all night, they have a meal together, he stays with them until early Sunday morning and now it's time for travel (due to the completion of the Sabbath).

In evaluating this passage as evidence of early Christian Sunday keeping, the eminent church historian, Augustus Neander, remarks:

"The passage is not entirely convincing, because the impending departure of the apostle may have united the little Church in a brotherly parting-meal, on occasion of which the apostle delivered his last address, although there was no particular celebration of a Sunday in the case"

The History of the Christian Religion and Church, tr. Henry John Rose, vol. 1, p. 337.

Colossians 2: 16…

The Hebrew word for Sabbath- שַׁבָּת [*shabbath* /shab·**bawth**/] occurs 111 times in the Old Testament, 94 times it is speaking of the Seventh Day Sabbath. 17 times it is talking about something else! So how can we know if it is speaking of the Seventh Day Sabbath in the Old Testament/New Testament? We can know due to the presence of certain syntactical & linguistic markers.

(OT Syntactical & Linguistic Markers) Seventh day Sabbath.

Key words:

- Keep, The, Day, Holy, My.

Concepts:

- Cyclical, context.

(OT Syntactical & Linguistic Markers) Not talking about the Seventh day Sabbath.

Key words:

- Afflict, Weeks, of the land, her/its, your.

Concepts:

- Context.

This of course only applies to the original Hebrew. But generally if you see any of these markers you can be sure the writer is speaking of the Seventh Day Sabbath. Whenever the Hebrew term "Shabbat" is accompanied by these linguistic markers it is always identified as the Seventh Day Sabbath, in every case there is at least one identifying marker.

In the New Testament, the Greek word for Sabbath- **σάββατον** [*sabbaton* /**sab**·BAT·ON/] occurs 68 times. The majority of the time it refers to the Seventh Day Sabbath but at times it is referring to something other than the Seventh Day Sabbath.

(NT Syntactical & Linguistic Markers) Seventh day Sabbath.

Key words:

- The, Day, Lawful, Synagogue, Keep.

Concepts:

- Cyclical, Context.

(NT Syntactical & Linguistic Markers) Not talking about the Seventh day Sabbath.

Key Words:

- One, First, Twice.

Concepts:

- Sometimes the context.

The other way that the word "Sabbath" is generally translated in the New Testament is "week" (approx 15% of time). So the word "Sabbath" in Greek can also mean the whole week! Because it is the last day of the week, it is easy for this to stand for the whole week. There are many places in the New Testament in the original Greek that mention the word Sabbath that are not presented in our English translations due to the translators supplying the word "week." This is done simply to make it easier for the reader to understand and the translators know that is what the word means.

Now with that in mind, when we look at Colossians 2: 16 none of the regular syntactical markers that would indicate it was the Seventh Day Sabbath are there in the original, we do however find the context statement following suggesting "which are a shadow of things to come" we know that the Seventh Day Sabbath was never a type or shadow of anything as it was presented to man prior to the fall. Additionally, it must be noted that this text Is a unique use of the word Sabbath in the New Testament due to the limit of markers presented, furthermore, there is only one other place in the Bible where we find "feasts/festivals, or a new moon or Sabbaths" in that order and in a group of three….***Hosea 2: 11.***

In the Old Testament, we learned about the linguistic markers surrounding the use of the word Sabbath. Now in **Hosea 2: 11**, do we find any of these linguistic markers? Yes we find the word ..."Her." Hosea 2 is a prophecy that God is going to put an end to all the appointed feasts of the Jews which includes:

- Her feast days.

- Her new moons.
- Her Sabbaths.

Note the use of a chiasm here.

The use of inverted parallelism in Hebrew literature or poetry is significant, as an understanding of this methodology will provide the reader a greater insight as to what message the writer is conveying.

chiastic poetry—in which the thoughts alternate, usually going from thought A to B and then back from B' to A'. If you diagram the pattern, you discover that the thoughts crisscross to form an X, which is the shape of the Greek letter chi, hence the words "chiastic" and "chiasm."



"The alternations of ideas … indicate that this … structure is not accidental, but rather an ingenious design of the poet … the Hebrew poet deliberately decided not to parallel precisely the word order of his poem by using the chiastic pattern."Although B may complement or even complete A, "Chiastic parallelism clearly avoids expressing the same idea twice. It rather aims at a sequence of thought which brings out the essence of the point more fully and sharply"

Gugliotto, Lee J.: Handbook for Bible Study : A Guide to Understanding, Teaching, and Preaching the Word of God. electronic ed. Hagerstown, MD : Review and Herald Publishing Association, 2001, c2000, 1995

So what are the feasts mentioned here in Hosea?

- The feast of Passover.
- The feast of booths (tabernacles).
- The feast of first fruits.

Now let's find out what the Sabbaths are that were being done away with.

Leviticus 23: 24…So in the seventh month on the first day of the month was to be a memorial of blowing of trumpets. This verse calls that day a Sabbath!

Leviticus 23: 27-32…now when speaking of the Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur), a reference of this being a Sabbath day is also made. So trumpets and Atonement were Sabbath days.

The Big picture: In the Old Testament there was a prophecy that God was going to put an end to certain Jewish Holydays. This consisted of:

- Feast days.
- New Moon celebrations (every month).
- Yearly Sabbaths that took place on the Day of Atonement and the feast of trumpets.

So in the New Testament, the apostle Paul in Colossians 2: 16 tells us that prophecy has been fulfilled with the coming of Messiah. Now why did God put an end to those Holydays?

Colossians 2: 17…

The type of Sabbath under consideration is shown by the phrase "which are a shadow of things to come" (Verse 17). The weekly Sabbath is a memorial of an event at the beginning of earth's history (Gen 2: 2-3; Ex 20: 8–11). Hence, the "Sabbaths/Sabbath days" Paul declares to be shadows pointing to Christ cannot refer to the weekly Sabbath designated by the fourth commandment but must indicate the ceremonial rest days that reach their realization in Christ and His kingdom (see Lev. 23: 6–8, 15, 16, 21, 24, 25, 27, 28, 37, 38).

Finger of God…

Exodus 312: 18… tables of stone, written with the finger of God.

Deuteronomy 9: 10… two tables of stone written with the finger of God.

Exodus 8: 19… magicians said unto Pharaoh, this is the finger of God: and Pharaoh's heart was hardened.

Luke 11: 20… but if I with the finger of God cast out devils.

Appendix: The Sabbath

Ecclesiastical History

Contemporary records also reveal the fact that the churches in Alexandria and Rome were chiefly responsible for promoting Sunday observance. About A. D. 440 the church historian Socrates wrote that "although almost all churches throughout the world celebrate the sacred mysteries on the Sabbath (Saturday)every week, yet the Christians of Alexandria and at Rome, on account of some ancient tradition, have ceased to do this" (Ecclesiastical History v. 22). About the same time Sozomen wrote that "the people of Constantinople, and almost everywhere, assemble together on the Sabbath, as well as on the first day of the week, which custom is never observed at Rome or at Alexandria."

- Three facts are thus clear: The concept of Sunday sacredness among Christians originated, primarily, in their effort to avoid practices that would tend to identify them with Jews, and thus lead to persecution.

- The church at Rome early developed a preference for Sunday; and the increasing importance attached to Sunday in the early church, at the expense of the Sabbath, closely parallels Rome's gradual rise to power.

- Finally, Roman influence prevailed to make the observance of Sunday a matter of church law, as it did with many other practices such as the worship of Mary, the veneration of saints and angels, the use of images, and prayers for the dead. Sunday sacredness rests upon the same basis as these other non-scriptural practices introduced into the church by the bishop of Rome.

Nichol, Francis D.: The Seventh-day Adventist Bible Commentary, Volume 4. Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1978; 2002, S. 833

First Record of Weekly Sunday Observance:

And we afterwards continually remind each other of these things. And the wealthy among us help the needy; and we always keep together; and for all things wherewith we are supplied, we bless the Maker of all through His Son Jesus Christ, and through the Holy Ghost. And on the day called Sunday, all who live in cities or in the country gather together to one place, and the memoirs of the apostles or the writings of the prophets are read, as long as time permits; then, when the reader has ceased, the president verbally instructs and exhorts to the imitation of these good things. Then we all rise together and pray, and, as we before said, when our prayer is ended, bread and wine and water are brought, and the president in like manner offers prayers and thanksgivings, according to his ability, and the people assent, saying Amen; and there is a distribution to each, and a participation of that over which thanks have been given, and to those who are absent a portion is sent by the deacons. And they who are well to do, and willing, give what each thinks fit; and what is collected is deposited with the president, who succours the orphans and widows, and those who, through sickness or any other cause, are in want, and those who are in bonds, and the strangers sojourning among us, and in a word takes care of all who are in need. But Sunday is the day on which we all hold our common assembly, because it is the first day on which God, having wrought a change in the darkness and matter, made the world; and Jesus Christ our Saviour on the same day rose from the dead.

For He was crucified on the day before that of Saturn (Saturday); and on the day after that of Saturn, which is the day of the Sun (Sunday), having appeared to His apostles and disciples, He taught them these things, which we have submitted to you also for your consideration.

Justin's Sunday Services:

The first clear, authentic, uninterpolated witness to regular Sunday observance among early Christians is Justin Martyr's First Apology, ch. 67: "On the day called Sunday, all who live in cities or in the country gather together to one place, and the memoirs of the apostles or the writings of the prophets are read. . . . Sunday is the day on which we all hold our common assembly". This Apology usually is considered to have been written at Rome in A.D. 155; there is, however, some evidence from Justin's other writings and from Eusebius that Justin may have observed Sunday when living in Ephesus before he came to Rome, and if so, as early as A.D. 135 or earlier.

Thus, until about the middle of the second century, there is no certain mention of Sunday as a weekly holy day, but after Justin's Apology (perhaps A.D. 155) there are a series of references to that day by various Church Fathers. It should be noted, however, that although evidence for Sunday observance can thus be traced back almost to apostolic times, this early Sunday observance amounted almost entirely to participation in religious services. Sunday was not confused with "Sabbath" and was not considered a day of obligatory rest until the sixth century or later.

Source: Justin Martyr, First Apology, chap. 67, trans. in ANF, Vol. 1, pp. 185, 186.
[p. 185]